# Chapter 7
# The Strategy of Presenting Persuasively

## Quotes

*"Think before you speak. Read before you think."*
***Fran Lebowitz***

*"As it is the characteristic of great wits to say much in few words, so small wits seem to have the gift of speaking much and saying nothing."*
***Francois de La Rochefoucauld***

*"The first rule of speaking is: Listen!"*
***Larry King***

## Presenting Persuasively: How You Are Evaluated

- Telling the story
    - Eye contact with the audience - don't look at the screen, the computer, or index cards and read the to the audience – know the information and tell your story
    - Engage the audience – call them out at the beginning, recognize contributors, respond to questions with names
- Using your voice
    - Passion
    - Pace – take your time. Use pauses to allow the audience to internalize information.
    - Emphasis – can I tell what's important
    - Dynamic Range – slow/fast; soft/loud
- Using Physicality
    - Movement – Move with purpose: move to the screen, move toward the audience, move back. Otherwise, stand still…don't walk around randomly, sway or teeter back and forth.
    - Gesticulation – Use your arms and body…smile! Do not put your hands in your pocket, use them.

## Presenting Persuasively: High Level Guidelines

There are three core speaking pillars to keep in mind when you're presenting:

1. Tell the story
    - Tell them what you're going to tell them
    - Tell them
    - Tell them what you told them
2. Focus
    - Relentlessly focus on the outcome
3. Know when to Stop
    - Once you've reached your outcome, stop talking!

Beyond the speaking pillars defined above, here a few thoughts to keep in mind:

- Remember, as with writing papers and creating presentations, that: “Proper Planning and Preparation Prevents Poor Performance.” Presenting is not something to just do. Your level of preparation will be evident to the audience. Practice presenting.
- Research, think and then speak. Know what you’re talking about. Carefully layout what you’re going to say and then say it
- Be concise and precise. Keep the storyline tight and focused on the desired outcome. Don’t meander and get off track
- Think like an actor. Use your capabilities of your voice, your eyes, and your body to convey the story is clearly and passionately as you can

## Twelve elements of Persuasive Argument

We’re going to examine twelve (12) elements to persuasively argue your goal.

1. Focus on your goal
2. Tailor argument to the decision maker
3. Cultivate ethos
4. Argue by reason
5. Argue with Evidence, experience and strategy
6. Appeal to emotion
7. Use the best medium
8. Strategically Arrange the Argument
9. Argue with Style
10. Use Delivery to enhance the message
11. Engage the Listener
12. Immunize and refute opposing points

### Focus on your goal

You should have a primary goal of your presenting. If you have many goals, it will make it hard for your audience to understand and focus.

- Clarify. Make sure that your primary goal is crystal clear in the minds of the audience members. There should be no doubt in anyone’s mind what you’re expecting of them
- Be realistic. Your primary goal should make sense to the audience and be something that is within their purview.

Maintain Focus. Stay focused on your goal.

- Avoid irrelevance.
- Avoid Tangents.
- Allow Spontaneity. Engage your audience, when you can. Listen to them carefully and use what they say to reinforce your message when possible.

Practice.  Make sure to practice you presentation. Make sure to practice your presentation out loud. It's amazing to perfect something sounds "inside" your head, but when you say it out loud it just doesn't seem to come out right.

- Expect questions and prepare answers. Take the position of the audience, and especially of those that might challenge you. Consider the questions they will ask and be prepared to answer or, better yet, include the information in the points that you make
- Develop transitions between different points in your presentation. If there are multiple speakers in your presentation, be sure to provide a transition from one speaker to the next, just like a baton is passed in a relay race.
- Concede weak points.  Know what your weak points are in your argument. Don't try to hide them.  When someone asks, acknowledge the weak point and continue with your other points.

## Tailor argument to the decision maker

Carefully consider the decision maker or makers in the audience and make sure that your goal, argument and points are relevant.

- **Seniority** — Core team members, management team, engineers, CIO
- **Power dynamics** — alone, direct reports, peers, customers, or more senior people
- **Number** — 1, 3, 8, 120 attendees
- **Location** — Conference call, open office, hotel, board room, hallway
- **Occasion** — Introduction, proposal, kick-off, training, readout, final presentation
- **Style and culture** — Direct, analytical, hierarchical, risk averse, self-discovery, formal
- **Language** — Taboos, terminology, politics, trusting, references
- **Duration** —15 minutes, one hour, all day
- **Roles** — Facilitator, presenter, advocate, catalyst, challenger, attendee

Understand the decision maker's attitudes and beliefs:

- Direction
    - Favorable
    - Unfavorable
    - Neutral
- Intensity
    - Weak
    - Average
    - Strong
- Salience
    - Relative importance

## Cultivate ethos

Ethos involves using ethical reasoning with an audience to get them to believe you.

### Elements of Ethos

In order to cultivate ethos, you must demonstrate the elements of ethos:

- Honesty

- Integrity
- Knowledge
- Goodwill
- Sincerity

### Ethos Tactics

Below are specific examples of what you can do to cultivate ethos:

- Source facts
- Avoid extreme positions
- Take opposing views seriously
- Organize your argument
- Do not read presentation
- Smile, be courteous
- Use audience members names
- Actively listen to each audience members statements and questions
- Never talk down to audience members
- Open with friendly conversation
- Be yourself
- Speak with conviction
- Be dynamic
- Be well-groomed

Build rapport with the audience when you're presenting. Watch the audience and listen to what they have to say. Although not obvious, think big ears, big eyes and small mouth when you're presenting.

- Smile
- Show interest in other people
- Encourage the other person to state their position or question
- Make the other person feel important
- Pay close attention to what the other person is saying

## Argue by reason

Both inductive and deductive reasoning can be used when arguing, this is also known as using premises to a conclusion. "Therefore" - inductive reasoning moves from specific instances into a generalized conclusion, while deductive reasoning moves from generalized principles that are known to be true to a true and specific conclusion.

### Deductive

Deductive reasoning is a logical process in which a conclusion is based on the concordance of multiple premises that are generally assumed to be true. Deductive reasoning is sometimes referred to as top-down logic. Deductive Examples:

- In mathematics, If A = B and B = C, then A = C.
- Since all humans are mortal, and I am a human, then I am mortal.
- All dolphins are mammals, all mammals have kidneys; therefore all dolphins have kidneys.
- Since all squares are rectangles, and all rectangles have four sides, so all squares have four sides.

### Inductive

Focus on the Inference, the generalization, analogy or causal correlation. Inductive reasoning, is sometimes referred to as bottom-up logic. Inductive examples:

- Pull a black marble from a bag, pull a second black marble from a bag, pull a 3rd black marble from the bag…all the marbles in the bag are black.
- Jennifer leaves for school at 7:00 a.m. Jennifer is always on time. Jennifer assumes, then, that she will always be on time if she leaves at 7:00 am.
- The cost of goods was $1.00. The cost of labor to manufacture the time was $.50. The sales price of the item was $5.00; so, the item always provides a good profit.
- Every windstorm in this area comes from the north. I can see a big cloud of dust caused by a windstorm in the distance; so, a new windstorm is coming from the north.

## Argue with Evidence, experience and strategy

Providing examples, especially leveraging examples that the audience is familiar can be helpful in supporting your argument. Use well know industry examples if possible. Make sure to demonstrate the relevance of the example, the "so what" tied to your argument.

## Appeal to emotion

Emotion provides motive, meaning, and context for "rational" thinkers. Use emotion in your presenting to engage your audience emotionally. Sometimes telling a story can be used to make your point.

## Use the best medium

Choose the best way to make your presentation. Leverage videos, audio clips, PowerPoint decks each at the right level of detail to get your point across.

## Strategically Arrange the Argument

### Introduction (Tell them what you're going to tell them)

Make a Strong First Impression.

- Make a startling statement
- Ask a question
- Use a quotation
- Tell a story
- State your purpose
- Pay a compliment
- Make a personal reference

### Body (Tell Them)

Use Various Structures to deliver the body of your argument.

- Chronology
- Evaluate alternatives
- Present problem and suggest solution
- Compare and contrast competing claims
- Keep points to 3 maximum
- Repeat key points

## Conclusion (Tell them what you told them)

Close with Passion

- Request the specific action you want
- Speak to heart of the argument

## Argue with Style

Use Rhetorical Tactics

- Style
  - Wit
  - Sarcasm
  - Irony
  - Humor
- Simplicity
  - Speak in a clear, precise, and direct manner
  - Use verbs instead of nouns
  - Use concrete rather than abstract words
- Word Choice
  - Vivid language
  - Avoid "consulting speak" Examples:
    - proactively facilitate exceptional innovation
    - synergistically envision corporate analytics
    - fungibly architect ubiquitous statistical models
  - Mix it up (Use a thesaurus)
- Rhythm

| Rhythm Type | Definition | Example |
|---|---|---|
| **Anaphora** | Repeating same word or groups of words at the beginning of successive clauses | "Let us go forth, let us fight, let us win." |
| **Epistrophe** | Repeat the same word or group of words at the end of successive clauses | "This is going to be built by us, with us, and for us." |
| **Anadiplosis** | Repeating the last word of one clause at the beginning of the following clause | "Aboard my ship excellent performance is standard. Standard performance is sub-standard. Sub-standard performance is not permitted." |
| **Climax** | Arranging words, phrases, or clauses in increasing importance | "The company's behavior was shameful, it was illegal, and it cost the plaintiff her life" |
| **Metaphor** | An implied comparison of two things that are unlike in nature but have something in common | "On the exam, several students went down in flames." |
| **Analogy** | An implicit comparison between like problems | "That will teach you to not bite the hand that feeds you." (from Aesop's Fable of dog in well); refer to tale later |
| **Simile** | An explicit comparison using words "like" or "as" | "He is as fit as a fiddle." |
| **Metonymy** | Substituting some attribute or suggestive word for what is actually meant | "She sets a fine table." In lieu of, "She is an excellent cook who can prepare a good meal." |
| **Aposiopesis** | A sudden halt in speech | "And this part is really important…" |

## Use Delivery to enhance the message

Use your voice and body to enhance the meaning of the message.

### Language and Word Choice

Choose the appropriate words to deliver the message. Avoid using slang if you're not sure that everyone in the audience will understand. The same applies to using technical language or acronyms. If you're not sure that everyone in the audience will understand, use non-technical descriptions and avoid using acronyms

- Clarity
    - Speak to be understood - make sure to enunciate clearly.
    - Have a structure and flow
    - Use examples
- Volume
    - Speak to be heard - Project your voice to be heard throughout the room
    - Project confidence
- Pitch, Tone, and Pace
    - Vary tone and pitch for impact
    - Slow down – take your time to explain
- Facial Expressions
    - Smile
    - Use when audience is talking to show interest
- Body Language and Eye Contact
    - Maintain eye contact
    - Gestures
    - Good distance from audience
    - Good posture – don't cross arms, stick your hands in your pocket or sway back and forth
- Transitions
    - One continuous presentation
    - Ride the coat tails of the person before you
- Time
    - Monitor time
    - Know when to stop

## Engage the Listener

Pace Your Argument to match the audience's mood and mind set. Allow the audience to participate in the presentation. Seek feedback from the audience. When you bring up a point that was raised by an audience member, use their name as a reference to that point. Ask rhetorical questions to get the audience thinking.

## Immunize and refute opposing points

There will be opposing points of view. Use the following to deal with opposing points of view.

- Employ mutually exclusive and collectively exhaustive (MECE) arguments. Basically, don't leave any room for anyone to question something –address every possible option.
- Explain or concede your weak points.

- Refute only significant facts.
- Refute errors directly. If someone brings up a point that is incorrect, make sure to carefully correct their misunderstanding.
- Don't quarrel. Getting into an argument with one or more of your audience members is not going to help your presentation. Suggest to take the discussion "off-line."

## Additional Resources:

The following video presentations are good examples to review to enhance your persuasive presentation skills.

- J Douglas Jefferys, "Killer Presentation Skills" https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=whTwjG4ZIJg
- Inc, "How to Improve Your Presentation Skills" http://www.inc.com/guides/how-to-improve-your-presentation-skills.html
- WordStream, "20 Ways to Improve Your Presentation Skills" http://www.wordstream.com/blog/ws/2014/11/19/how-to-improve-presentation-skills
- MindTools, "How Good are Your Presentation Skills?" https://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newCS_96.htm
- The Mobile Studio Company, "Presenting & Public Speaking Tips – How to improve skills & confidence" https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Q5WT2vweFRY